



AVIATION

FOGGY SKIES

The recent disruptions in the aviation industry may be directly linked to foggy skies, but more pertinent issues like shortage of staff and aircraft loom large

BY ARNAB DUTTA

► **EVERY WINTER**, the skies of North India turn unusually gloomy—disrupting normal operations of aircraft and trains alike. This time, as dense fog engulfed the areas in and around the national capital region of Delhi (Delhi-NCR), cracks in the idea of a resurgent aviation sector began to show. While fog-related disruptions have impacted flight operations—ripples of which are felt across the country—experts point towards deep-rooted issues that have made the situation worse for passengers and industry stakeholders alike.

InterGlobe Aviation, the parent company of market leader IndiGo, was recently slapped with a fine by the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS). The company, which has a 54% share of the market, has now found itself in the proverbial eye of the storm, especially after a disgruntled customer assaulted its staff. It faced the wrath of the authorities after videos emerged on social media of passengers from one IndiGo flight rushing out of the aircraft and sitting on the tarmac in Mumbai, eating their food on the spot. The incident occurred when a Delhi-bound flight

from Goa was diverted to Mumbai due to lack of visibility.

While the airline has put the blame on the dense fog, customers took to social media to describe how airline staff had been unco-operative from the beginning, which made the situation worse.

That, however, didn't stop the authorities from issuing show-cause notices to both IndiGo and the Mumbai International Airport Ltd (MIAL), followed by penalties from BCAS of ₹1.2 crore on IndiGo and ₹60 lakh on MIAL. The DGCA imposed a ₹30-lakh penalty on MIAL.